

"I HOPE WE CAN **LEAVE**
THE **PAST** BEHIND
US AND **FOCUS** ON
OUR **FUTURE**."

QIU JIN, *AN ADDRESS TO HER 200 MILLION FELLOW COUNTRYWOMEN*, 1904

education emphasized the importance of being a virtuous wife and good mother. With reforms in the early 20th century and the establishment of new girls' schools, the education system began to extol gender equality. Books and periodicals urged women to participate in actively changing society. The most influential work on women's liberation during this period was the male writer Jin Yi's *Nüjie zhong* (*The Women's Bell*) (1903), which stressed that there was no distinction in moral conscience and intellectual ability between men and women.

Many Chinese intellectuals also advocated for the idea of women's full emancipation in marriage. Confucian scholar Kang Youwei looked forward to traditional marriage being replaced with a series of one-year contracts. The May Fourth Movement of 1919 raised awareness of sexual equality; during the protest men and women interacted with each other in public and advocated making marriage a free choice – a right finally granted in 1950.

◀ **Bound by beauty**

Foot-binding began when a girl was around 4 years old. To create "golden lily" feet, the four smaller toes were crushed under the sole and the rear of the anklebone was flattened.



▲ **Aesthetics of cruelty**

A pair of lotus shoes for bound feet, which were seen as highly erotic in Chinese culture. Women had to take tiny steps, adopting a swaying "lotus gait."



BIOGRAPHY **QIU JIN**

A revolutionary Chinese feminist, Qiu Jin was born into a well-to-do liberal family in 1875. In 1903, she left her husband and children to pursue an education in Japan. Upon her return to China in 1906, Qiu cofounded the *Chinese Women's Journal*, which promoted women's emancipation. She argued that liberated women were crucial for a strong Chinese nation. In 1907, however, Qiu was executed for her part in an unsuccessful plot to overthrow the government.